

Automate the Provisioning Process for Cloud Inventory

This article describes how to automate the provisioning of cloud inventory on www.digitalocean.com and is based on how the author's own company went about doing so.



The SaaS offering from Sastra Technologies, a firm that I co-founded, promises customers their very own database, which means that each customer has a separate database for its operational data. This puts a lot of pressure on our engineering team to ensure the database is provisioned and the SaaS widgets are up and running within minutes of the customers signing up. In the beginning, we were inclined to run a few shell scripts and have these set up by an engineer; however, we soon realised that our customers are based in the UK and could sign up while we were asleep. We had to enable this by automating the entire provisioning process. We initially looked at Puppet, Chef and FAI but these solutions had a pricing plan and, being a start-up, our aim was to conserve funds. So we decided to roll out our own provisioning scripts using the Digital Ocean API.

The case for automation

We had several compelling reasons for automating our provisioning. The primary reason was to guard ourselves against our inability to scale and provide infrastructure in case there was a flood of sign ups, especially in the middle of the night. Automation would also ensure that subsequent environments would be identical to those set up previously —this is important because we didn't want components to fail due to differences in the versions of the underlying infrastructure components.

The background

Digital Ocean (DO) is a cloud computing provider and is ranked 15th among hosting companies in terms of Web-facing computers, according to a news item in Netcraft (<http://news.netcraft.com/archives/2013/12/11/digitalocean->